

KF51 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

We always begin the next Karis Fellowships training cycle in March. Everyone who wishes to continue with KF must register in order to have access to the KF website and community. If you haven’t registered already, take a minute right now to register, either on the KF website or through the link in your email. Let’s just pause and breathe while members register. (*Pause 1 minute*) Registering now will remove a burden from the hard-working KF admin team and will also keep you connected to the website. If KF admin does not receive your registration, the system will disconnect you and move you to the “inactive” list.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

When we practice KF Confession 12, our trust in the karis relationship with God grows:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

Scientific research attests the benefits of mindfulness training and meditation. Hundreds of studies have shown that these practices strengthen our immune system, increase mental focus, promote a sense of well-being, and decrease symptoms of depression and anxiety.¹ Meditation, in particular, improves self-esteem and fosters self-acceptance, leading to greater esteem and acceptance of others.² You can imagine how these benefits improve your ability to productively manage your relationship with yourself and with others—and even your relationship with God.

Our practice for this month is **Waiting on the Lord**. The goal of this meditation is to learn to wait, simply wait, before the Lord. You might feel that this is a waste of time and wonder, “What is this waiting doing for the Lord? What is it doing for me? Doesn’t God want me to get up, get on with my work, fix the world, and become glorious?” Yet there are many verses in the Bible that encourage us to learn to wait on God. John Milton, the great 17th century English poet, wrote his extraordinary epic poem, *Paradise Lost*, after he had lost his sight. Blindness could have destroyed his career as a writer and, also, could have restricted his contribution to the community. So, how did he manage such a crushing limitation? He managed his limitation and even thrived because he knew this truth: God is not interested in our search for an imagined glory; He is interested in teaching us to wait on Him and trust.

Listen to these words written by John Milton:

“Doth God exact day-labor, light denied?” I fondly ask.
 But Patience to prevent that murmur soon replies:
 “God doth not need either man’s work or His own gifts;
 Who bear His mild yoke, they serve Him best. His state is kingly.
 Thousands at His bidding speed and post o’er land and ocean without rest.
 They also serve who only stand and wait.”³

Take a deep breath.

“They also serve who only stand and wait.” When things don’t go our way, the struggle to be patient is just as difficult for us today as it was for Christians hundreds of years ago. When light or clear direction is denied, our human tendency is to be discontent. We want to fight our limitations because we imagine that they restrict our happiness and potential and interfere with our service to God. Developed patience does not murmur against God, however. It understands that in waiting—in exercising patience—we also serve. We may not become famous poets, but by learning to wait productively, we choose to trust the creative power of the Holy Spirit, who is able, even in our present darkness, to reveal the glory of God.

Waiting on the Lord

Assume a meditation posture. With your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth, close your eyes and begin with one minute of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. (*Pause for 1 minute*)

Pause, and allow your shoulders and arms to drop into a relaxed position. Now, as you breathe, observe your body. Can you allow your muscles to relax and release tension? Breathe, and invite your body to let go with the exhale. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

Keeping your eyes closed, look up at the inside of your forehead. Imagine that you are looking into a light that is pouring into your face. (*Pause*) As you inhale, you might explore pulling energy up from the earth through your tailbone, filling the spinal column and brain. Then, as you exhale, allow the energy to drain back into the earth. Practice for one minute. (*Pause for 1 minute*)

At some point, you might imagine that you are gazing into the face of Jesus or into the glory of God. Just silently absorb, wait, and breathe for one minute. (*Pause for 1 minute*)

Pause, and gently open your eyes. Take a deep breath and re-engage with the meeting.

Our hymn for the last month of our training is *Be Thou My Vision*.

Be Thou my battle Shield, Sword for the fight;
 Be Thou my Dignity, Thou my Delight;
 Thou my soul’s Shelter, Thou my high Tower:
 Raise Thou me heavenward, O Power of my power.⁴

Take a deep breath.

(*If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”*)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION**0:21 TOOLBOX**

KF Confession 12 reminds us of the benefits of circulating our resources:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

Last week, we touched on the idea of flow. When we start living from our True Self and are able to maintain our connection to the Creator and the Creation, karis gifts begin to flow toward us. Our response is to send gifts back out into the Creation. By doing so, we keep the karis connection with our Creator circulating and flowing. This is a very exciting, surprising, and fascinating process through which we build a relationship with God based on gratitude and trust. Everything that you have is a gift from God, and when you respond by returning gifts to God, you pump the energetic flow of the Creation. Perhaps in last week's meeting you understood something of the purpose and promise of living in the flow of circulation. Just like in a dance, we accomplish one step with joy and then immediately give ourselves to the next step without any judgment about how it should be or what we should receive in return.

Hopefully, by now, you have some understanding of the incredible folly and misorientation of judgment. In every situation, judgment will destroy both your potential and the potential of others. You can only fulfill your marvelous design with all of its possibilities if you give up judging yourself, others, and life. Your potential is only realized when you believe what is actually happening and then respond authentically to that reality.

Without doubt, our energy has been damaged by the misorientation of others. However, acting like a human filtering system, we can cleanse that misoriented energy through our lives and choices and return oriented energy to the Creation. As a friend of God in karis relationship, you become the means of liberating others; you conquer injury with active good.⁵ One way of doing this is to circulate the gift of forgiveness. You forgive by letting go of the debt that you hold against yourself or against others—and, also, any debt that in your misorientation you hold against God. God sends rain on both the oriented and the misoriented, and when you walk in orientation and forgiveness, flowing in the freedom of your relationship with Him, you too will send rain on both the oriented and the misoriented, watering every thirsty soul that you touch.⁶

In the flow of circulation, there are seasons of giving and seasons of guarding, so it's important to learn when to let go and when to hold on. That takes practice. Some feel the strain of violating taboos when they hold on; others feel the strain when they let go. The karis relationship will always require both guarding and giving, so if you want to stay in the flow, you must learn when to hold on and when to let go. You start by practicing with small things, which trains you for greater opportunities and challenges. You are learning to let go of, or lose, your Idol's life with its pride system and fear.⁷ Hoarding any area of the MATH—whether money, abilities, time, or health—supports the Idol and cuts off circulation. That is called greed. On the other hand, indiscriminately scattering your MATH exhausts your resources. That is called dissipation. Those resources are then no longer available for oriented circulation.

When you feel like hoarding or exhausting your resources, you might ask yourself, "What am I afraid of?" Remind yourself that the Idol is at work, and then let go. Hoarding is based on the fear of loss—fear of losing support for the Idol, fear of strengthening someone else's position, fear of losing control or power, fear of not getting our own way, fear of not being appreciated or valued, fear of exhaustion. It's all fear.

Fear of our responsibilities as stewards often results in dissipation, and we justify our choices with the virtue story that if we don't have anything, we will have no responsibilities and, therefore, no fears.

There is misorientation, and there is wisdom. Misorientation serves our fears and saves our pride. Oriented wisdom serves love and seeks to bring everything into harmony. When we circulate wisely, we invest in lives and situations that are moving toward orientation. Prudent giving is a component of karis.

I am learning to give with discretion, regardless of how guilty or compelled I feel when I refuse to give. Budgets help me resist compulsive feelings. Guided by A-S-A-P—Ask, Simplify, Adventure, Prioritize—I have created budgets that honor my limitations, help me set priorities, protect me from compulsive giving or hoarding, and make provision for authentic generosity. For my own inner harmony, I adhere to those budgets. I have also developed the habit of watching for opportunities to support others who are making an effort to be on God's team. By supporting such people, I support God, and by supporting God, I support myself. As you practice A-S-A-P and adjust to what you learn in your experiments, you will stop frittering away the gifts of your MATH on instant gratification and image management. Frittering is a way of avoiding your true glory and mission. Learn to see where the energy is flowing and use your gifts to get on board.

How are you circulating your MATH? How do you feel when called upon to offer your MATH without any expectation of personal return? How do you feel when you choose not to give? What are your principles of circulation? What priorities guide your giving?

In our next lesson, we will look at some principles of circulation that may help you establish your priorities.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Show me today where You are working, Lord, so that I might offer a karis gift to You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

Next week will be our last lesson in the KF cycle and traditionally, during the presenting time, members share how they support their community or what they do for a living. You might also prepare for the sharing time by reviewing your Meeting Preparation Guides and highlighting a few of the beneficial changes you have experienced this past year.

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

The purpose of the KF Confessions and our training is to lead us to the new level of trust expressed in KF Confession 12:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

Let's read **First Peter 4:1–11** in my translation, which includes a little paraphrase for clarity. This passage summarizes the goal of our training.

¹Therefore, since Christ has suffered in the material experience, arm yourselves also, like soldiers, with the same understanding, because those who suffer in the material experience have made an end of misorientation. ²They are therefore able to live the rest of their time in the material existence no longer reacting to the compelling needs and cravings of humanity but, instead, responding to the desires of God. ³Look at it this way: In your former life, you spent plenty of time working hard to achieve the goals of misoriented people while those same people made you bear wanton violence toward yourself and others. They encouraged you to live egocentric lives filled with unexamined longings, unrestrained addictive behaviors, mindless gratifications, and all the activities of serving and worshipping your own Idol Self and theirs. ⁴They are now surprised and think you very strange because you no longer choose to run with them into the same wasteful enthusiasms, which by their character and outcomes slander God. ⁵They will give an account of their actions to the One who carries the responsibility and is also ready to judge the living and the dead.

⁶This is how it works: the good news is preached even to those who are dead so that the quality of their choices can be revealed and examined. They are dead according to the flesh of humanity, but the good news is told even to those who are dead so that they might live according to the Spirit of God. ⁷For the fulfillment of all things is near. Therefore, come to your senses; be mindful and not drunk in your prayers.

⁸Above all, exercise agape love purposefully and intentionally among yourselves, because agape covers much misorientation. ⁹Be hospitable to one another without grumbling about it. ¹⁰Since you have received a gift from God, be like excellent household stewards and circulate that gift by serving each other. Karis giving is beautiful and intricate, like an embroidered work of many colors. ¹¹If one of you has something to say, speak with mindful consideration as if you were speaking an oracle of God. If one of you serves or ministers, don't do it to indulge the pride and the illusions of the Idol's imagined glory, but do it out of the strength that God supplies so that as we express Jesus Christ in this world, God may be glorified in everything and in every way, to Whom is the glory and the mastery forever and forever. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

The main point of this passage is this: productive suffering is part of the process of learning to effectively circulate. When we suffer, we learn to endure, and our endurance produces character that is mature, complete, and lacks nothing. ⁸ If we lack nothing, we have the freedom to circulate. If you choose to follow Jesus, you can expect to suffer; suffering will always accompany your move toward orientation. You are in a birthing process, and through productive suffering you learn to cooperate with your own birth. You have spent plenty of time fulfilling the compulsive strivings of your culture and background, and these strivings have caused you to suffer unproductively. It is now time for you to live in the oriented flow of new birth. The energy of this flow is agape love, which is manifested in how we interact as a karis community. We interact by offering to each other the gifts that God has given to us, and this giving weaves together a beautiful and intricate environment that nurtures and supports our healing and our growth. This wholesome environment is not something we can enforce or control with legal systems, and that's why it baffles those around us who have not yet come alive in karis.

It's time to stop trying to save your Idol's life by defending and maintaining your pride system. When you

humbly participate in karis circulation, you are circulating with God. You are on His side. Through this circulation, God's generous and magnanimous attributes are displayed to a stagnant and fearful world, inviting those who live there to reconnect with their Creator. Everyone has gifts to give, and if you are giving and receiving encouragement and giving and receiving gifts, you are in the flow of karis circulation. Everything you do as an expression of karis honors and glorifies your Creator.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Great Giver of karis gifts, help me get into the flow of circulation. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider stepping into the karis flow. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider stepping into the flow*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can sometimes be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently allow your experience to remain in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings or thoughts from our consciousness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever you may be experiencing as you *consider stepping into the flow*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider stepping into the flow*. What sensations are you experiencing? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what curiosity, the fear of loss, or the fear of losing control feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest for a few breaths. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the arms of Jesus as together you *consider stepping into*

the karis flow. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge the flow as good or evil, interesting or scary? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider stepping into the flow? *(Pause)* What area of trust in God might you explore? What scares or bothers you about karis? What are you holding onto? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the circulation of living in faith.
- Welcome the Holy Breath, who is constantly circulating.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁹

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I step into the karis flow, I let go of the craving to control my future.
- As I step into the karis flow, I let go of the craving to support my self-esteem.
- As I step into the karis flow, I let go of the craving for predictable comfort and safety.
- As I step into the karis flow, I let go of the craving to have things go my way. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together to train our trust and heal our fears. Sustain us as we explore the terrors of karis flow while You guide us to our goal. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we respond to your invitation to reorient our lives to karis and to strengthen our trust in You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

We always begin the next Karis Fellowships training cycle in March. Everyone who wishes to continue with KF must register in order to have access to the website. If you have invited someone to the NHG Study, please plan to support them by attending the upcoming KF Introductory Meeting.

¹ www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3679190/.

² www.psychologytoday.com/blog/feeling-it/201309/20-scientific-reasons-start-meditating-today.

³ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/When_I_Consider_How_My_Light_is_Spent.

⁴ www.youtube.com/watch?v=ihJAJA4ibEs.

⁵ Rom. 12:21.

⁶ Matt. 5:43–48.

⁷ Matt. 10:39.

⁸ James 1:4.

⁹ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.